Transformational Evolution of Language

Transformational evolution refers to a type of evolution in which an existing system undergoes a **substantial structural or functional change**, resulting in a new form or organization. In linguistics, it can describe changes in a language that **reorganize its grammatical, semantic, phonological, or syntactic system**, rather than merely producing small variations.

- **Word-order transformation**
- The relative order of constituents changes.
- SOV→SVO
- Example:
- *John the book read. → John read the book.*

In historical linguistics, a language may gradually shift from one dominant word order to another.

- **Passivization**
- The grammatical prominence of the subject and object is reorganized.
- *The boy broke the window.*
  The window was broken by the boy.
- The object of the active construction becomes the grammatical subject of the passive.

- **Question transformation**
- A declarative structure is reorganized to form a question.
- *She is coming.*
  Is she coming?
- In some languages, this involves movement; in others, particles or intonation may be used.

- **Negation transformation**
- An affirmative construction is reorganized into a negative construction.
- *He came.*
  He did not come.
- Languages differ considerably in how negation is structurally expressed.

- **Topicalization**
- An element is moved or positioned so that it becomes the **topic** of the discourse.
- *I like this book.*
  This book, I like.
- The second construction gives special discourse prominence to *this book*.

- **Cleft transformation**
- A sentence is reorganized to give special emphasis to one constituent.
- *John bought the book.*
  It was John who bought the book.
- Clefting changes the information structure of the sentence.

- **Relative-clause transformation**
- A noun phrase is associated with a subordinate clause to form a relative construction.
- *I met the woman.*
  I met the woman who wrote the book.
- Historically, languages may develop new relative-clause strategies.

- **Nominalization**
- A verbal or clausal structure is transformed into a noun-like structure.
- *The committee decided to reject the proposal.*
  The committee's decision to reject the proposal.
- Nominalization can substantially alter the syntactic organization of information.

- **Subordination transformation**
- Two independent propositions become structurally related through subordination.
- *It rained. We stayed home.*
  Because it rained, we stayed home.
- This is especially important in the historical development of **complementizers and subordinate-clause constructions**.

- **Coordination transformation**
- Independent structures become linked through coordination.
- *John came. Mary came.*
  John and Mary came.

- **Complementation transformation**
- A clause becomes structurally dependent on a verb, adjective, or noun.
- *I know.*
  I know that he came.
- This is particularly relevant to the historical development of **complementizers**, an area closely related to your research.

- **Argument-structure transformation**
- The relationship between a predicate and its arguments changes.
- For example:
- *The door opened.*
- may historically develop a causative counterpart:
- *John opened the door.*
- The construction changes from an **intransitive** structure to a **transitive/causative** structure.

- **Causativization**
- An event is structurally represented as being caused by another participant.
- *The child slept.*
  The mother made the child sleep.
- The syntactic structure gains a new **causer** argument.

- **Ditransitivization**
- A construction develops an additional recipient/goal argument.
- *John gave a book.*
  John gave Mary a book.
- The argument structure becomes: